

Debian 6.0 Squeeze: What's New?



With its extremely long release cycle (this one took two years), Debian 6.0 Squeeze was rolled out on February 6th, amidst jokes like, “See you in 12 months’ time,” and “So they finally ‘squeezed’ it out the door, eh?” Though its release has been accompanied by less fanfare and buzz than that of Lenny (the previous release), Debian 6 does come with gigatons of new features. Let’s have a look at them, in this *LFY*-exclusive review of Debian 6.0.

For the uninitiated, Debian is the world’s second-oldest surviving GNU/Linux distribution, released only a few months after Slackware’s first release. It’s also got a bit of romance attached to it—the name Debian derives from the names of Debian’s founder, Ian Murdock and his then-girlfriend (later wife, and now ex-wife), Debra Lynn. Debian is one of the two major ‘parent’ distributions today (the other being Fedora), which means that most other distributions are built on top of either Debian or Fedora. Debian’s claims to fame include its revolutionary package-management system consisting of DEB packages, Aptitude and Synaptic; its unmatched stability and speed; and the fact that it’s the parent to the world’s top two Linux distributions (by popularity): Ubuntu and Linux Mint.

Major changes

Debian 6.0 took 24 months to cook. With all that time on the burner, there had to be some major changes. So what are they? Well, for starters, Debian 6 is the first Debian release to feature the KDE Plasma Desktop, as the Debian guys choose

to call KDE4. The Debian 6 software package versions almost mirror Ubuntu’s 10.04 LTS release, with KDE 4.4.5, GNOME 2.30, Kernel 2.6.32 and OpenOffice.org 3.2.1 making it to the release.

Debian 6.0 now officially supports Sun’s (now Oracle’s) ZFS filesystem. Yes, you read that right—ZFS, including booting from it. How? Well, Debian, apart from now using the Linux kernel, also uses the FreeBSD kernel. There are two ‘technology preview’ architectures called *kfreebsd-i386* and *kfreebsd-amd64*, which feature the FreeBSD kernel running underneath Debian’s standard GNU user-land. This affords users the best of both worlds, but a couple of kinks do remain, and some advanced functions in the desktop environments don’t exactly work well. This also means that it’s the first time ever that a Debian distro has been rolled out with major bugs still unresolved.

Debian 6 makes two more major system changes, and both concern the internal design on the OS. Debian has switched to the free Linux kernel, which means all non-free firmware is now missing from the distribution, severely crippling hardware support. However, all the non-free firmware is still available; it’s just been moved to the non-free repository. This segregation offers the best of both worlds: purists can now run a completely free